Chapter 3 - Importing International Best Practice

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This chapter uses three international business frameworks (PESTEL, Porter's Five Forces and VRIO) to answer one question: what should the Hillview STEM Skills Program borrow from proven overseas models? The program will not expand offshore or recruit international students. Instead, international analysis is turned inward, so that lessons tested abroad can be adapted for Australian school students and young adults, particularly in regional New South Wales.

This mirrors how the King's Foundation itself grows. The **Design and Education Director of The King's Foundation Australia** explained that the Dumfries House model was first exported around the Commonwealth and is now being adapted to Hillview, with each country's programs reshaped for local context.

The program's primary goal is SDG 4 (Quality Education), particularly target 4.4: increasing the number of young people with technical and vocational skills. It also advances SDG 5 (Gender Equality), because women hold only about 16% of Australia's STEM-qualified jobs (Department of Industry, Science and Resources [DISR], 2025), and supports regional development in the Southern Highlands. Following feedback to analyse a few comparisons properly rather than many loosely, three benchmarks were selected.

Three international benchmarks

Each benchmark solves a problem Hillview will face: proving the model within the King's Foundation, reaching students beyond the site, and funding education sustainably.

Benchmark	Country	Model	Scale and revenue evidence	Lesson for Hillview
Dumfries House STEM programme, King's Foundation (The King's Foundation, n.d.)	Scotland, UK	Morphy Richards Engineering Education Centre, opened 2015; hands-on workshops for ages 5–18 in aerospace, green energy, environmental science, sustainable design and STEM on the farm (Dumfries	Co-delivered with ScottishPower, UTC Aerospace and Selex-ES; ScottishPower Foundation funding (ScottishPower, n.d.); girls-only engineering events (Dumfries House, 2017); teacher CPD	Industry co-delivery and sponsorship; dedicated pathways for girls

Benchmark	Country	Model	Scale and revenue evidence	Lesson for Hillview
		House, n.d.)		
4-H (Sirangelo, 2023)	United States	National youth network teaching agriscience STEM through clubs, camps and the hybrid Clover online platform	About 6 million youth; 3.6 million agri/earth-science projects a year; Bayer Science Matters reached 65,000+ youth (National 4-H Council & Bayer, n.d.); US$10.5m earned revenue in 2024 (AgriNews, 2025)	Digital platform extends reach; corporate agribusiness partners
Stone Barns Center for Food and Agriculture (Khalife, n.d.)	United States	80-acre working farm about 40 km from Manhattan used as an outdoor classroom	100,000+ visitors a year (Candid, n.d.); income from grants, donations, farm sales, program fees and venue hire	Diversified revenue so education is not fee-dependent

Dumfries House is the closest comparison because Hillview is explicitly modelled on it (Wingecarribee Shire Council, n.d.). Its STEM centre shows that a heritage estate can credibly host engineering education when industry partners supply content, equipment and funding (Dumfries House, n.d.). Its female-only engineering events respond to evidence that far fewer girls than boys consider engineering careers, aligning directly with SDG 5 (Dumfries House, 2017). The **Design and Education Director** noted that Dumfries now runs 12 education streams, including an agricultural training college, all intended for Hillview's 143 acres.

4-H demonstrates that practical, agriculture-based STEM works at national scale, covering hydroponics, drones and soil health (Sirangelo, 2023). Stone Barns proves that a farm-education centre can cross-subsidise learning through tourism, produce and events (Khalife, n.d.). This matters because the $1 million endowment must return more than 3% or Australian GDP growth, whichever is higher.

Importantly, international transfer works when methods, not settings, are copied. A **Professor at Washington University in St. Louis** described applying lean techniques used at General Motors and Siemens to smallholder fish farms in West Africa, lifting average net margins from about 6% to 50%. Hillview should likewise import Dumfries' teaching methods rather than its buildings.

PESTEL: does the Australian environment support the imported models?

Factor	Australian condition	International lesson	Implication for Hillview
Political	Federal *Advancing Women in STEM* strategy; NSW syllabus emphasises STEM	Dumfries worked with local authorities to fit the school curriculum	Map every workshop to NSW syllabus outcomes so excursions are easy for principals to approve
Economic	Tight school and family budgets; high transport cost for regional schools	4-H programs fund busing and scholarships (AgInfo, n.d.)	Sponsor-funded transport bursaries for low-SES and remote schools
Social	Declining STEM interest among 12–17-year-olds (Science & Technology Australia, n.d.); women only 3% of VET STEM occupations (DISR, 2025)	Dumfries girls-only engineering days	Termly girls-only agri-tech days with female mentors (SDG 5)
Technological	Agri-tech, drones and sensors growing in farming	4-H Clover hybrid platform	Online pre- and post-visit modules using live estate sensor data
Environmental	Bushfire, drought and extreme-heat risk in the Southern Highlands	Stone Barns uses the farm itself as the laboratory	Environmental monitoring curriculum; indoor and digital backup for cancelled days
Legal	Working With Children Checks, Child Safe Standards; Hillview is State Heritage listed	–	Use modular, non-invasive learning spaces; budget for compliance and insurance

Three PESTEL findings matter most. First, the social factor is both the main threat and the program's purpose. Australian girls and regional students are under-represented in STEM, particularly in vocational trades, where women hold only 3% of jobs (DISR, 2025). Importing

Dumfries' female-only events addresses this directly. The **Design and Education Director** also stressed that Hillview sits on Gundungurra land, so estate-based science modules should be co-designed with traditional owners rather than copied from Scotland.

Second, economic, legal and political factors limit how much can be copied. Schools are price-sensitive, and the State Heritage listing restricts alterations, so a purpose-built centre like Dumfries' is unrealistic within five years. Reliance on an overseas parent is also a risk: a **Banking Operations Officer at HSBC** described how the bank's decision to exit Australian retail banking closed her former team immediately. Hillview should therefore secure Australian funders and partners from the outset.

Third, technology lowers the cost of reach. Like 4-H's Clover platform, a digital layer lets students in western NSW learn from Hillview's estate data without travelling.

Porter's Five Forces: how attractive is the Australian market?

Force	Strength	Evidence
Competitive rivalry	Moderate	Questacon, CSIRO Education, university outreach, museums and PIEFA compete for school STEM time (NSW Department of Education, n.d.)
Threat of new entrants	Low	Land, heritage assets, a royal-linked brand and child-safety compliance are costly to replicate
Threat of substitutes	High	Free classroom resources, PIEFA's no-cost materials, virtual excursions
Buyer power	High (schools); lower (families, corporates)	Schools choose among many excursions on tight budgets
Supplier power	Moderate–high	Qualified STEM educators are scarce in regional NSW; industry partners control specialist equipment

The market is moderately attractive, with one serious weakness: substitutes are free. PIEFA provides agricultural STEM resources to schools at no cost (CivicGraph, 2026), so Hillview cannot win on price for classroom content.

Stone Barns faces the same problem in the United States and responds by selling what substitutes cannot: a hands-on experience on a working farm. Hillview's value likewise lies in using soil sensors, flying drones over paddocks and testing water on the estate, not in worksheets.

Supplier power is the second constraint, because qualified STEM educators are scarce regionally. A **People Partner at Canva** described how, early in his career, training every colleague in a complex process cut customer wait times from 45 minutes to five. Hillview can apply the same train-the-trainer model, preparing teachers and industry volunteers to deliver its modules.

Buyer power is high for schools but lower for families booking holiday camps and companies sponsoring programs. Diversifying customers, as Stone Barns does, reduces dependence on the most powerful buyer group. The threat of new entrants is low: few rivals could reproduce Hillview's combination of heritage estate, farmland and the King's Foundation name.

VRIO: which Hillview resources create lasting advantage?

Resource	Valuable	Rare	Hard to imitate	Organised	Outcome
King's Foundation brand and royal patronage	Yes	Yes	Yes	Partly – Australian arm only launched October 2024 (PA Media, 2024)	Potential sustained advantage
Heritage working estate (gardens, farmland)	Yes	Yes	Yes	No – restoration ongoing, no programs yet	Unused advantage
Dumfries STEM curriculum and know-how	Yes	Yes (in Australia)	Partly	Yes – shared Foundation network	Sustained advantage if localised
Australian industry partner network	Yes	–	–	Not yet built	Competitive gap
Online	Yes	No	No	Not yet built	Competitive

Resource	Valuable	Rare	Hard to imitate	Organised	Outcome
learning platform					parity

The VRIO analysis shows that Hillview's most valuable resources are rare and hard to copy, but not yet organised to capture value. The estate is still being restored, and the Australian foundation is two years old.

This is why international benchmarking matters. Most imported lessons address the "O" in VRIO: Dumfries shows how to organise industry partnerships, 4-H how to organise digital delivery, and Stone Barns how to organise revenue. The missing resource, an Australian industry network, is realistic to build. The **Director of Incubation and Entrepreneurship at Macquarie University** explained that EY and PwC send partners to teach in its design-thinking program because their recruiters gain access to future talent. Regional agribusiness and energy employers facing skills shortages have the same incentive to co-deliver Hillview workshops.

Recommendations and critique

Rather than copying every overseas idea, Hillview should import three practices, phased over five years.

1. Industry co-delivery and girls' pathways (Dumfries House, years 1–2). Recruit three or four anchor partners from regional NSW agriculture, energy and engineering to sponsor themed workshops. Run a girls-only agri-tech day each school term, led by female industry mentors, to advance SDG 5. Offer paid, NSW-accredited teacher professional development as a further revenue stream.
2. Diversified revenue (Stone Barns, years 1–2). Fund accessible school pricing through school-holiday camps, public weekend workshops, venue hire and sales of estate produce. This reduces exposure to the high buyer power of schools identified in the Five Forces analysis.
3. Hybrid digital delivery (4-H, year 3 onward). Once on-site content is proven, launch low-cost online modules built on live estate data so remote and low-SES students can participate before or after a visit. Sponsors would fund transport bursaries, following the 4-H model.

Each stream should be reviewed annually. A **Senior Accountant at Lighthouse Service Partners** described using historical performance and forecast macroeconomic trends to recommend that a client exit a consistently underperforming division. Hillview should apply the same discipline, closing any stream that fails to cover its costs after two years.

This analysis has limitations. An **Analyst at the Law Society of NSW** emphasised that decisions are only as sound as the quality of the underlying data. Here, most benchmark data comes from the organisations' own publications or media coverage, which may overstate success, and some

Dumfries sources date from 2017–2019. 4-H's reach of six million youth also relies on US public extension funding with no Australian equivalent. Sponsorship assumptions should therefore be stress-tested at half their expected level. Despite these limits, the benchmarks consistently show that practical, place-based STEM can be financially sustainable when revenue is diversified and industry is a genuine delivery partner.

Ai Disclamer

I did the research and drafted the report, then claude was used to finalise the grammar and spelling. Claude was also used to help to find other organisations which I could use as examples when looking at international business practices.

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